

But, for those on budgets who want excellent value for money, and don't really care if their speakers look like they're manufactured on Venus, buy the JBL Creature II. The set costs Rs 6500—just about a third of the price of the Bose.

Quadraphonic Sound (4.1)

This category is for people who want surround sound, which is, of course, not possible with a 2.1 system. The products we tested here were again the premium sets from Altec Lansing—the 641 and the AVS 500B—and the Creative Inspire 4400, as well as the Cyber Acoustic CA4100.

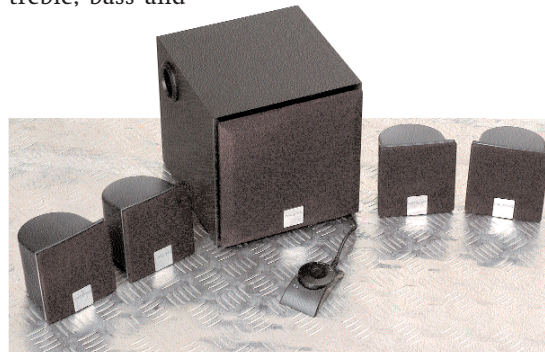
Straight out of the box, the speakers were beginning to look impressive, until we took out the Altec Lansing AVS 500B. This set was so unbearably bad-looking that we wanted to drop it—from the test, that is! The build quality was just abysmal—the rear of the woofer looks like it is made of plywood!

The speaker didn't perform any better than it looked either, and this was a shocker, as Altec Lansing is generally known for

high-quality products. The other Altec Lansing, the 641, however, looked as sturdy as a tank.

The Creative speakers also had decent build quality, and the Cyber Acoustic set was just plain ordinary. But the Altec Lansing 641 was simply in a league of its own!

In terms of features, none of these had Digital Input, SPDIF or coaxial inputs. Only the Creative and the Altec Lansing 641 came with remotes—both wired. The Altec Lansing 641 remote was the most comprehensive, with controls for surround, treble, bass and



Creative Inspire 4400 (4.1)

volume. The Creative only offered bass and volume.

Sounding Them Out!

As always, we started out with our bass and treble power tests. The Altec Lansing 641 aced them. Housing dual drivers in its massive woofer case, this speaker set decimated the opposition. It has a massive 109-watt subwoofer, as compared to the meagre 14-watt and 17-watt ones of the Altec Lansing AVS 500B, the Creative Inspire 4400, and the Cyber Acoustic CA4100.

The Altec Lansing 641 topped all our bass and treble tests, followed by the Creative Inspire, with the Altec Lansing AVS 500B coming in third and the Cyber Acoustics last.

In our DVD audio tests, the Altec Lansing 641 was again in a league of its own, scoring nearly twice as much as the nearest competitor, the Creative Inspire 4400.

The Cyber Acoustic comfortably beat the AVS500B in all DVD audio tests except for the vocals, where Eric Clapton sounded flat and hollow. This trend was replicated in all our music tests. The 641 was miles ahead, and left the Creative Inspire 4400 with the title 'best of the rest'.

The speaker that shone somewhat here was the Cyber Acoustic CA4100. It managed to equal or beat the Altec Lansing AVS 500B in every music test. The voice clarity of the Altec Lansing 641 was simply outstanding, with every tremor in Dido's voice being reproduced with aplomb.

What we really liked about the Altec Lansing 641 was that even at high volumes, the speaker never sounded like it was going beyond its capabilities. To be fair, though, it did succumb at the maximum volume level.

We then popped in our DTS sampler disk and ran our movie test. With the 641, we could hear every groan and creak of the cars, every tyre squeal and every rev of the engine as they raced along the massive truck. The Creative, with its good bass reproduction and clarity sounded good too, but was no match for the Altec Lansing 641.

The Winner Is...

Despite significant weightage being given to price, we still had to concede that the Altec Lansing 641 was the clear winner. It

How Speakers Work

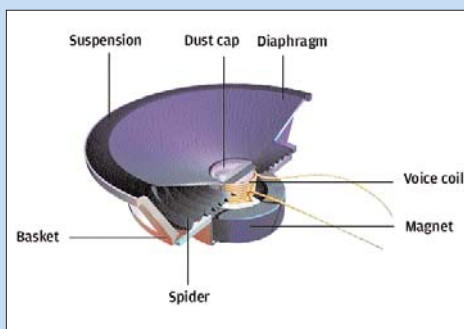
To understand how speakers work, you need to first understand how sound works. At the very basic level, an object produces sound by vibrating the air particles around it. These in turn vibrate those next to them, and so on, until the sound reaches you.

The speaker translates electrical signals into sound by creating the requisite vibrations. Depending on the accuracy of the vibrations that are produced, we classify the speakers as good or bad!

The sound from a speaker is produced using one or more drivers. The driver produces sound by vibrating a diaphragm.

The diaphragm, which is conical in shape, can be made up of plastic, metal, and even paper! In fact, you can make basic (but bad-sounding) speakers from everyday chart paper!

The narrow end of the diaphragm is then connected to something called the voice coil. This coil is then placed in the magnetic field of a permanent magnet.



When you pass a current through this coil, it turns into an electric magnet, and will have the properties of a regular magnet—but unlike a regular magnet, on reversing the flow of current, the polarity of the magnet changes.

Now when we alternate the current flow in the coil, it keeps changing the magnetic forces between the coil and the permanent magnet. This moves the coil back and forth—due to attraction and repulsion—and moves the diaphragm along with it.

This movement of the speaker cone vibrates the air around it leading to sound production.